



BEFORE

In European warfare, cavalry was held in high regard, traditionally seen as an elite arm with decisive impact. The U.S. Army, by contrast, had neglected it.

ATTITUDES TO CAVALRY

The first two U.S. Army regiments to bear the “cavalry” designation were not established until 1855. In 1861, these two units existed alongside three other mounted units: two of dragoons (a kind of cavalryman) and one of mounted infantry. The Union government was **prejudiced against cavalry**, considering it expensive and frivolous.

In Europe, the traditional role of the cavalry was threatened by the **increased firepower** of both **infantry and artillery**. This was clearly demonstrated in the disastrous **Charge of the Light Brigade in 1854** during the **Crimean War**.



FRENCH SHAKO, OR CAVALRY HAT

More used to horses as a means of transportation, the South utilized cavalry from the war’s outset. Self-consciously “aristocratic” Confederates were attracted to the dashing image of cavalry, and mounted regiments were formed by volunteers enlisting with their own horses. The impressive performance of General Jeb Stuart’s 1st Virginia Cavalry at Bull Run in July 1861 stimulated enthusiasm for mounted units on the Union side too. The government swiftly established the centralized supply of horses and equipment. Volunteers to the Union cause were not generally accomplished horsemen, and many troopers had to be taught the basics of riding. The South continued to depend on men providing their own mounts, which were cared for by enslaved laborers. If their horse was killed, they had to go home and find another or accept transfer to the infantry. Capturing or stealing horses became crucial for Confederate cavalry as the war went on, since the Union controlled major sources of mounts in Missouri, Kentucky, Tennessee, and West Virginia.

Practical weapons

Neither side adopted the European practice of flamboyant cavalry uniforms, although there was the occasional flourish, such as the peacock feather Jeb Stuart wore in his hat. The saber was traditionally regarded as the true weapon of the cavalryman, but in